THE ABLE FOUNDATION PRESENTS · ABLE: UNSCRIPTED

Beyond the Bell

Episode 01 · Participant Profiles · Creative & Cultural Impact Pillar

5 confirmed participants

Jeremiah L. Thomas

6th Grade Language Arts Teacher

Anne Arundel County Public Schools

Annapolis, Maryland · 4 years in education

Jeremiah Thomas is a dedicated educator and graduate student in Transformational Educational Leadership at Towson University, where he will be graduating soon. He is committed to fostering inclusive, student-centered learning environments that support both academic success and personal growth. With experience working in diverse and urban school settings, Jeremiah prioritizes building strong relationships with students while maintaining high expectations and a classroom culture rooted in respect, accountability, and open-mindedness.

His teaching philosophy emphasizes collaboration, critical thinking, and real-world application. He designs engaging, standards-based instruction that encourages students to take ownership of their learning while strengthening their literacy and communication skills. Jeremiah is especially passionate about supporting middle school students during critical developmental years.

Jeremiah values God, family, and community, which guide both his personal life and professional practice. Outside the classroom, he is a devoted father who believes in leading by example and giving back to those around him. He strives to model integrity, resilience, and empathy, with the goal of inspiring students to become confident, responsible, and thoughtful individuals.

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Dr Blake

(Dr. William Blake)

Author/Educator

The Ai School Leader

Washington DC · 20 years in education

Dietary/Access: Na

Dr. William L. Blake is an award-winning educator and school leader with over 20 years of experience serving students and communities across Washington, DC and Prince George's County Public Schools. He currently serves as the Assistant Principal of Bard High School Early College DC, where he leads the 9th Grade Academy, ensuring students are academically successful, connected to school, and prepared for what's next.

Dr. Blake's teaching and leadership philosophy centers on creating joyful, rigorous, and student-centered learning environments where every student feels seen, heard, and valued. He believes strong relationships, high expectations, and culturally responsive practices are essential to unlocking student potential and driving meaningful outcomes.

Throughout his career as a teacher, principal, and district leader, Dr. Blake has led innovative work in school redesign, social-emotional learning, and early college access. He is also the author of The AI School Leader, a practical guide that helps educators use artificial intelligence to lead with greater efficiency, innovation, and impact while keeping students at the center.

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Jay headshot

Jay

(Jarrell Pittman)

PBIS Coordinator/ Restorative Practices Teacher

KIPP DC: Quest Academy

Washington, D.C. · 10 years in education

Dietary/Access: Peanut/Tree nut Allergy

Jarrell Pittman is an educator and creative entrepreneur from Prince George's County, MD, dedicated to storytelling across various mediums. With KIPP DC, he has advanced from Grade-Level Chair to a key role on the Student Support team. As the PBIS Coordinator and Restorative Practices Teacher, he shapes school culture, facilitates school-wide programs and events all while centering the teaching of life skills, conflict resolution, and emotional regulation.

Outside the classroom, Jarrell works with arts-based non-profits to develop educational programs for children and adults. He also leads Tha Griotsphere Productions, a company that combines storytelling, teaching, and media to offer audiovisual services, workshops, programs, both virtually and in person. Through Tha Griotsphere, Jarrell collaborates with numerous organizations on both commissioned and in-house projects. He also serves on the board of Rhythm Visions Production Company, a non-profit dedicated to arts equity and social justice.

Whether performing as an emcee or teaching in the classroom, Jarrell's mission is to inspire others to explore their own stories and embrace their personal journeys.

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Desmond

(Desmond Williams)

Teacher

Nylinka School Solutions

Washington, DC · 24 years in education

Desmond Williams was a teacher and principal in the Washington, DC area for over 20 years. He is committed to supporting Black boys and underserved children. He is also the author of The Burning House: Educating Black Boys in Modern America.

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J. Rahdi Jefferson headshot

J. Rahdi Jefferson

(Jacquez Rahdi Jefferson)

8th Grade Action Civics Instructor

E. L. Haynes Public Charter School

Washington, DC. · 10 years in education

Dietary/Access: Halal

J. Rahdi Jefferson brings lived experience, creativity, and deep reflection into everything he does—especially the classroom. Many of his fondest memories and personal growth moments were formed in NW/NE DC and Upper Marlboro, MD, places that continue to influence his storytelling and perspective.

Inspired to write at a young age, Mr. Jefferson discovered writing as a powerful form of expression. That passion evolved into authorship during his college years at the University of Maryland Eastern Shore and has since grown into a body of work that spans poetry, children's literature, and reflective prose. To date, he is a self-published author of five books, each rooted in purpose and perspective.

His educational impact has reached multiple grade levels and his work with students academically has been multicurricular. Currently he teaches 8th grade Action Civics at E. L. Haynes Middle School in NW, DC. He currently serves and studies as an Athari Fellow of the National Association of Black Male Educators.

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